

Q&A

Your Questions, Our Answers

Too Much RAM?

Q I have a P IV computer that I bought in 2002. My problem is that all of a sudden, my PC displays a blue screen and it restarts by itself. I don't know what to do. Recently, I installed a 128 SDRAM module on top of the existing 128 MB SDRAM module. Is the problem due to the RAM?

Tenzin Sherab, Manali

A There is a good chance that the new RAM module you installed is faulty, or incompatible with the motherboard or the older RAM module, or both. You'll need to get the new RAM module replaced. Take your old RAM module to the vendor from whom you bought it and ask him to replace the new RAM with one similar to the old RAM.

I Can Watch But Can't Catch!

Q I have an Intel Celeron 1.2 GHz, 256 MB RAM, a 60 GB hard drive and a Frontech TV-Tuner card. The TV playback of the card is smooth enough. But while recording, many frames are lost in the DVD quality. As a result, the quality of recording is poor. How can I ensure best quality?

Mahesh Bandekar, via e-mail

A The system configuration you mention is more than enough to view TV using a TV-Tuner card. But it is not enough to record live TV in DVD quality. You can record in MPEG-1 file format (VCD quality) without dropping a frame, but if you try to record a MPEG-2 file format (DVD quality), you will drop a lot of frames and the resulting captured file will be of bad quality.

If you wish to record in MPEG-2 format, you should consider upgrading your hardware to at least a 2 GHz processor from Intel or a 2000+ processor from AMD. To capture in MPEG-2 with really good quality, you will require a TV-Tuner card with hardware MPEG capture capability, such as the ones from Hauppauge.

Power Trouble?

Q My PC's configuration is as follows: an AMD Athlon 64 3000+, an Asus K8N4E Deluxe nForce 4 chipset-based motherboard, XFX GeForce PCX 5300 PCIx16, a Tricom 450 watt, iBox i612 Standard ATX, a Seagate 80 GB 7200 rpm SATA hard drive and Windows XP Professional SP2.

The problem arises when I start playing games like *Call of Duty* or *Prince of Persia—Warrior Within*. It runs fine initially, but after playing for 10 to 15 minutes, the PC hangs and restarts.

I have checked the CPU and motherboard temperatures—they were stable at 48 and 46 degrees Celsius respectively. All overclocking options are disabled and there is no overclocking. Is there a problem with my power supply? I'd asked my vendor for a genuine 400 W power supply. He recommended the Tricom 450 W, and I purchased it.

Devadatta, Bhubaneswar

A Install DirectX 9.0c on your PC. Install the latest versions of nForce4 chipset, nVidia graphics and AC'97 audio drivers for your motherboard. Install the latest hotfixes for Windows XP SP2. If the problem persists, your RAM is the probable cause. This is more likely if there is a slight mismatch in the RAM modules in the dual-channel configuration.

To figure out if this is the case, remove one of the RAM modules and try playing the game to see if it works. If it doesn't crash, the problem is with the mismatched memory modules. If the problem persists, there could be some heating issues with your processor. You can't always depend on the motherboard's temperature sensor to report the correct temperature at all times.

More For Less?

Q Using my Windows 2000 bootable CD, I can install Windows 2000 Professional, Windows 2000 Server and Windows 2000 Advanced Server. When I checked the size of the disk by right-clicking the CD drive icon, it was around 450 MB. But when I tried to copy it to my hard disk, it took around 1.5 GB.

I've also come across some 770 MB VCDs, although the normal disk capacity is 700 MB. How can one write more data on a CD than its pre-defined capacity?

Prasad V Nair, Trivandrum

A Some data CDs are created in such a way that although the total size of the data on each may far exceed the normal capacity of a CD (which is 700 MB, and may sometimes even cross 1 GB), the CD properties still show the CD's size to be well within the limits.

This is achieved by a special method of CD image creation wherein identical files appearing multiple times in the CD compilation are stored as a single file with different entries in the file allocation table of the CD. This way, multiple identical files that are seen to occupy multiple times the size of the file actually occupy only the space of a single file. There are various tools available to create such images, including UltraISO at www.ezbsystems.com/ultraiso.

A Useful Dump

Q When memory dumping happens, '.dmp' files are created. Can you tell me how to open these files to know the reason of the dump?

Adesh Kumar, via e-mail

